



1927–1997 · United States Air Force colonel and strategist.

"Whoever can handle the quickest rate of change survives."

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Boyd wanted to know why a force that was slower or smaller could still win. His answer was tempo: the side that observes, orients, decides and acts faster forces its opponent to react to a world that has already changed.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

A fighter pilot and aeronautical engineer, Boyd developed energy–manoeuvrability theory and then a broader theory of conflict. He never wrote a book; his ideas live in briefings such as 'Patterns of Conflict' and 'A Discourse on Winning and Losing'.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the OODA Loop, central to Unit 1's decision-intelligence theme and Unit 5's treatment of business agility as the speed of organisational re-decision.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

OODA operationalises as a continuous cycle in which the orientation step — shaped by experience and mental models — is decisive, and tempo is treated as a weapon.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

OODA is sometimes reduced to a simplistic 'go faster' slogan, losing Boyd's emphasis on orientation and on disrupting the opponent's cycle. Its empirical generality beyond aerial combat is debated.

ENDURING IMPACT

OODA has migrated from the cockpit into business strategy, cybersecurity, agile practice and litigation, becoming a default model of adaptive decision-making.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 1)

Russell Ackoff · Giant 1

Clayton Christensen · Giant 3

Jan Carlzon · Giant 4

W. Chan Kim & R. Mauborgne · Giant 5

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Boyd, J. (1986) 'Patterns of Conflict' (briefing).

Osinga, F. (2007) *Science, Strategy and War: The Strategic Theory of John Boyd*. London: Routledge.